

CABINET BRIEFING • MARCH 2027

# Defensible-Space Standard

Whether to mandate 30-meter vegetation clearance for the 41,000 homes in the wildland-urban interface.

# The bottom line: mandate the clearance standard, phased over three fire seasons.

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A statewide 30-meter defensible-space requirement is the single intervention that most reduces structure loss per dollar. We recommend adopting it now, with a graduated enforcement schedule and a hardship grant for low-income owners.

# Last season's losses concentrated where vegetation met structures.

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The 2026 Coyote Ridge fire destroyed 612 homes. Post-incident survey found 83% of lost structures had less than 10 meters of cleared vegetation; 91% of surviving structures within the same burn perimeter exceeded 20 meters.

- Clearance, not construction year, was the strongest predictor of survival.
- The pattern repeats across four of the last five major incidents.

# Voluntary guidance has not moved compliance in eight years.

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The interface has carried a *recommended* 30-meter guideline since 2019. Self-reported audits put voluntary compliance at 34% — flat since the guideline was issued, and concentrated in higher-income parcels with the means to clear.

# Three policy paths, scored against what the standard must achieve.

## Keep voluntary guidance.

- ✓ Low cost
- ✗ Compliance gain
- ✗ Equity reach

Cheapest to administer, but eight years of flat compliance show it does not change behavior at scale.

## Mandate with no support.

- ✗ Low cost
- ✓ Compliance gain
- ✗ Equity reach

Drives compliance but lands hardest on owners who cannot afford clearance, inviting non-compliance and appeals.

## Mandate with hardship grants.

- Low cost
- ✓ Compliance gain
- ✓ Equity reach

Achieves the compliance gain while funding the owners least able to clear. Recommended.



EVIDENCE • MODELED OUTCOMES

# What the mandated standard buys over a five-year horizon.

*Modeled against the 2019–2026 incident record, applied to the current interface parcel set.*



# What any acceptable standard had to satisfy.

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01

## **Measurable loss reduction**

Must show a defensible link to reduced structure loss, not just activity.

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02

## **Enforceable at scale**

Compliance must be verifiable across 41,000 parcels without doubling inspection staff.

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03

## **Equitable burden**

Cost must not fall hardest on the owners least able to bear it.

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04

## **Fundable within the envelope**

Total cost must fit the \$340M resilience appropriation already authorised.

# Where each path sits on enforceability against equity.

**Hard to enforce • Inequitable.**

Status quo voluntary guidance

**Hard to enforce • Equitable.**

Incentive-only tax rebates

**Enforceable • Inequitable.**

Flat mandate, no support

**Enforceable • Equitable.**

Mandate with hardship grants

# What the standard costs across the three-season phase-in.

|    |                                  |                                                        |        |
|----|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| 01 | Year 1 — high-risk zones         | 9,200 parcels, including 1,800 hardship grants.        | \$74M  |
| 02 | Year 2 — moderate-risk zones     | 18,600 parcels, including 3,100 grants.                | \$121M |
| 03 | Year 3 — remaining interface     | 13,200 parcels, including 1,500 grants.                | \$98M  |
| 04 | Recurring — inspection & renewal | Annually from Year 4, absorbed by the resilience fund. | \$14M  |

# The chief risk is enforcement capacity, and it is addressable.

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Inspecting 41,000 parcels needs roughly 40 additional seasonal inspectors. We propose remote-sensing pre-screening to triage parcels, reserving field visits for likely non-compliance — cutting required headcount by an estimated 60%.

# Adopt the mandated 30-meter standard with hardship grants, phased over three seasons.

## ADOPT MANDATE WITH GRANTS

Delivers the loss reduction while funding the owners least able to clear.

## WHY NOT STAY VOLUNTARY

Eight years of flat compliance show guidance alone does not change behavior.

## WHY NOT MANDATE WITHOUT SUPPORT

Equitable burden was a hard requirement; an unfunded mandate fails it.

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**A standard that survives the next  
fire season, not just this briefing.**